environmental standards, or financial oversight, further fuels accusations of sovereignty erosion.

Key developments have exacerbated these tensions. First, IOs have expanded their autonomy. IOs have grown more independent from member states, with bureaucrats and leaders leveraging their positions to pursue specialized agendas. For instance, the IMF's increasing focus on climate change reflects not just member-state priorities but also bureaucratic initiatives (Clark and Zucker 2024). Organizations like the WTO and the EU have similarly been criticized for stretching their mandates to encompass broader regulatory roles, further intensifying populist opposition.

Second, elite staffing of IOs has increased as bureaucracies have expanded in size. IOs increasingly hire large numbers of credentialed experts from prestigious institutions, reinforcing perceptions that they are out of touch with ordinary citizens (Chwieroth 2015).

Third, IOs have been affected by technological advancements. Real-time surveillance, AI, and big data analytics have enabled IOs to operate more independently, often without direct state oversight. While these technologies enhance IO effectiveness, they also deepen perceptions of their unaccountability.

The populist backlash against IOs is not simply a rejection of their missions but a broader critique of how they wield power. While nonpopulist critics, such as former US president Barack Obama, have expressed concerns about whether global commitments overstretch state resources, populist leaders frame their opposition ideologically. For them, IOs represent a fundamental incompatibility with national sovereignty and the will of "the people."

In this evolving landscape, IOs face mounting challenges to their legitimacy and functionality. Yet these threats have also spurred innovation and adaptation. By expanding their missions, forming partnerships with NGOs and private actors, and embracing new technologies, IOs are finding ways to remain relevant in an increasingly polarized world. The central question is whether IOs can balance their growing authority with the need for legitimacy among both member states and global publics. Populists argue that they cannot, and have taken it upon themselves to challenge IOs' central role in global governance.